Past tenses and used to

Objective: To talk about past events and past habits correctly, choosing between the past simple, the past continuous and **used to**.

The idea in two lines: The past simple tells finished actions; the past continuous describes an action in progress at a past moment. **Used to** describes past habits or states that are no longer true today.

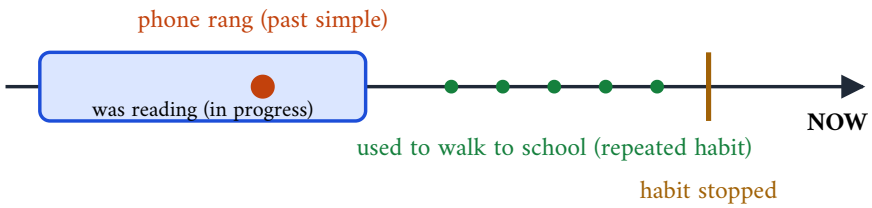


Figure 1: A finished action interrupts an action in progress; "used to" covers a repeated past habit that stopped before now.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Past simple:** verb + -ed (regular) or the second form (irregular): *went, saw, wrote*. Used for finished actions at a definite time (*yesterday, last year, in the past*).
2. **Negative and question:** did / didn't + base form: *Did they travel? They didn't travel.*
3. **Past continuous:** was / were + verb-ing. It describes an action in progress at a moment in the past.
4. **When / while:** *While* + past continuous (long action); *when* + past simple (short action that interrupts).
5. **Used to + base form:** a past habit or state that is no longer true: *People used to write letters.*
6. **Forms of used to:** negative *didn't use to*; question *Did you use to …?* (no -d after did).

🟢 Examples

1. Put the verbs in the right tense: "I (watch) TV when the lights (go) out." **Answer:** I *was watching* TV when the lights *went* out. **Explanation:** a long action interrupted by a short one.
2. Rewrite with *used to*: "In the past, my grandfather rode a horse to the market. He doesn't now." **Answer:** My grandfather *used to ride* a horse to the market.
3. Ask a question: "Children played in the streets." **Answer:** *Did* children *use to play* in the streets?

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing *didn't went* instead of **didn't go**: after did, use the base form.
- Writing *Did you used to …?* instead of **Did you use to ...?**
- Confusing *used to + base form* (past habit) with *be used to + -ing* (be accustomed to).
- Using the past continuous with state verbs: say *I knew*, not *I was knowing*.

🟡 Quick review

- Finished action ⇒ past simple.
- Action in progress ⇒ was / were + -ing.
- While + long action, when + short action.
- Past habit that stopped ⇒ used to + base form.
- After did / didn't ⇒ use (not used).

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